equivalent. Under him, France conquered most of the Continent while on the gold standard, and the Germinal Franc was to remain stable until 1914.

Germany During the Weimar Republic[24]

Emperor Wilhelm II and the German Parliament decided to fund their World War I efforts entirely by debt. When Germany lost the War, the new Weimar Republic had to not only service this debt, but also pay the war reparations. Since the reparations had to be paid in gold or hard currency, the Weimar Republic resorted to mass printing of Marks, with which they then purchased hard currency to pay the reparations.

This resulted in a complete breakdown in the value of the Mark and galloping hyperinflation. In the first half of 1922, 1 US dollar was worth 320 marks; by November 1923 it was worth 4.2 trillion marks.[25]

The law and order situation deteriorated rapidly across the country. The galloping hyperinflation naturally placed great pressure on the state. On 9 November 1923, Adolf Hitler, leader of the Nazi party, attempted to seize power through the infamous Beer Hall Putsch and was put on trial and eventually imprisoned for treason. He used his time in prison to evolve his forthcoming political and military strategies and to write *Mein Kampf*. Many historians attribute his rise and success in German politics to the hyperinflationary episode of 1921–23.

In September 1923, the Weimar Republic finally took steps to stabilize their economy. The newly appointed Chancellor, Gustav Stresemann, declared a State of Emergency. In October, the Rentenmark Ordinance was published, allowing for a new currency, the Rentenmark – equivalent to the gold linked pre-War Mark – to be issued by a new institution, the Rentenbank.